sympathising manner in which we were received by this Chief who immediately on learning that we were hungry and thirsty ordered a cloth to be spread on the ground where we were sitting.'[55] He welcomed them to his blazing camp fire, offered them dinner, then refused to allow them to return to their troops. Shelton was furious and demanded the right as an officer and soldier to return to lead his men and die fighting. He was refused.

By nine the following night, after a day under continual fire, and when it was clear that all the remaining leaders had either been captured or killed, most of the survivors, 'now almost maddened with hunger and especially with thirst having been marching or rather hunted like wild beasts for 24 hours', decided that their only hope was to press on in the dark. They found however their way blocked by a formidable thorny barrier of 'prickly holly oak, well twisted together, about six feet high', which had just been erected across the narrowest part of the pass.[56] Those who tried to tear it down with their bare hands or claw their way up it were shot down as they did so. Very few made it over. One who failed to do so was the sepoy Sita Ram. He recorded how,

> when the General sahib left, all discipline fell away. As a result, the Afghans were able to annoy us the more . . . A number of sepoys and followers went across to the enemy in an effort to save their lives. My regiment had disappeared and I attached myself to the remnants of a European regiment. I thought that by sticking to them I might have some chance of getting away from that detestable country. But alas! Alas! Who can withstand fate? We went on fighting and losing men every step of the road. We were attacked in front, in the rear, and from the tops of hills. In truth, it was hell itself. I cannot describe the horrors. At last we came to a high wall that blocked the road; in trying to force this, our whole party was destroyed. The men fought like Gods, not men, but numbers prevailed against them. I was struck down by a jezail ball on the side of my head.

Sita Ram was knocked unconscious, and when he came to he found himself:

> tied crossways upon a horse which was being led rapidly away from the fighting towards Kabul. I now learned that I was being taken there to be sold as a slave. I begged to be shot, or have my throat cut and abused the Afghans in Pushtu and in my own language . . . but my captor threatened to make me a Muslim on the spot if I did not keep quiet. What dreadful carnage I saw on that road – legs and arms protruding from the snow, Europeans and Hindustanis half buried . . . It was a sight I shall never forget as long as I live.[57]

One of the very few to make it over the holly barrier was the last surgeon left alive, Dr Brydon. 'The confusion became terrible,' he remembered,